has come from anywhere in India that people are suddenly falling sick after taking these vaccines.'[22] After careful evidence-based consideration, on 25 December, the prime minister announced that in order to protect our most vulnerable groups, a pre-caution dose akin to a booster dose would be given to frontline workers, senior citizens and those over 45 years of age with comorbidities. He also announced that children between 15–18 years would be eligible to be vaccinated.[23] The prime minister also announced that a nasal vaccine would soon be available in India. A couple of days later, on 28 December, the DCGI approved two new vaccines, both manufactured in India: SII's Covovax and Biological E's Corbevax. The DCGI also approved molnupiravir, an antiviral drug which would be manufactured by 13 companies in India for restricted use under treatment of adult patients with COVID-19 who show a high risk of disease progression.[24] Covovax, a nanoparticle vaccine and Corbevax, India's first indigenously developed RBD protein (a critical component of the viral spike glycoprotein that is found in coronaviruses including SARS-CoV-2) subunit vaccine have both shown about 90 per cent efficacy in clinical trials. With these second-generation vaccines and drugs, India's arsenal has grown immensely to combat the virus with its variants.[25] Even as India worked on augmenting its resources, new research poured in about Omicron being some kind of an endemic-stage variant. A released pre-print paper showed that Omicron infection enhances neutralizing immunity against the Delta variant which essentially means that when an individual is infected with Omicron, the chances of him being reinfected with Delta goes down. The researchers also noted in their concluding remarks that, 'Along with emerging data indicating that Omicron, at this time of the pandemic, is less pathogenic than Delta, such an outcome may have positive implications in terms of decreasing the COVID-19 burden of severe disease.'[26]

While the debate is still on regarding the need to lock down cities as infection rates surge, many believe that with a less pathogenic variant like Omicron, perhaps a measure of damage must not be the number of registered cases anymore but rather the number of hospitalizations. Data coming in from various cities around the world have reported significantly lesser hospitalization rate as compared to previous variants.[27] The Indian response continues to be alert, cautious and watchful in order to fight the impending surge of cases which many cities have begun to experience.